a certain area—usually an empty stretch. The officers set out to nab them in the wee hours, ask them to surrender, get bullets for an answer. In retaliatory firing, the accused are hit in the leg, usually between the knee and ankle. They are then taken to hospital, bandaged and paraded limping before the media.

GROWING COUNT

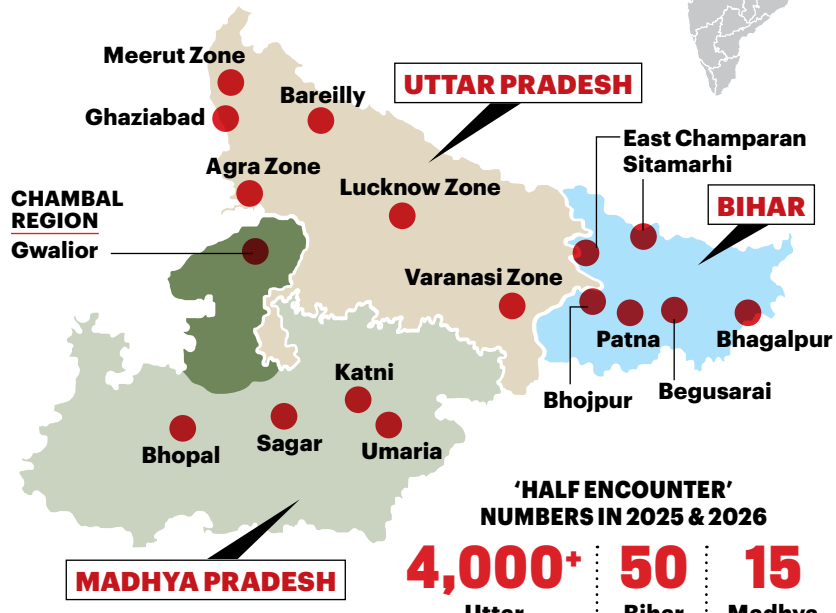
The fact that states have a specific terminology for the practice suggests that it is widely seen as a deliberate police response to crimes that evoke public outrage. It helps if the accused are 'habitual offenders', with little political support. The numbers, too, indicate that shooting in the leg seems to be the preferred option over shooting to kill. The Bihar Special Task Force's own balance sheet this year (January 1 to August 16) records 19 encounters, three criminals killed and 18 injured. A wider tally for Bihar Police has more numbers in the 'encounter' and 'people shot in the leg' columns. In UP, under Yogi Adityanath's 'tough on crime' regime, there have been an average of five encounters a day and one encounter killing every 12 days since the BJP came to power in 2017. According to available figures, in 2025 and 2026 alone, 97 people were killed and more than 4,000 injured in such encounters,

In MP, the Gwalior-Chambal region, once known for its free-ranging dacoits, still tops the charts for 'short encounters'. The MP police do not record every instance where an alleged criminal is shot in the leg, but it does dutifully register a case of 'attempt to murder' against said persons after each encounter. A former state DGP, who did not wish to be named, says shooting someone in the shins is "in some ways a sign of helplessness of the police". "There is no surety of punishment which would have otherwise created deterrence in the minds of criminals. One can't completely blame judicial delays for this; a fair part of the blame has to be shared by the police too."

HAIR TRIGGER RANGE

The crime hotspots where the chances of being crippled go up exponentially





Source: UP and Bihar govt and police reports, news reports from MP

'HALF ENCOUNTER' NUMBERS IN 2025 & 2026

4,000+	50	15
Uttar Pradesh	Bihar	Madhya Pradesh



"If a criminal has the freedom to open fire, then the police also have guns to confront them. They are trained precisely for such situations, to make the offender understand in a language that he knows"

–YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh, at the 2026 UP Pharma Conclave

A LAW UNTO THEMSELVES

The police in many states may think differently, but the country's laws provide no separate track for instant justice. In fact, the Supreme Court said as much in a 2014 case ruling addressing encounter killings (*People's Union for Civil Liberties vs. State of Maharashtra, 10 SCC 635*), saying the state has no authority to violate the right to life under Article 21, and that a plea of self-defence cannot close the file on a death in police firing. Then chief justice, R.M. Lodha, and Justice R.F. Nariman, in their order, laid down 16 mandatory guidelines for 'encounter' cases. This includes, among other rules, the tip-off being recorded, an FIR if a death follows a firearm discharge, an investigation by an independent agency, a magisterial inquiry under Section 176 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, forensic tests, and no out-of-turn promotion for the officers involved. The National Human Rights Commission's